

SEEKING **PEAK SUCCESS** ON THE OLYMPIC ROLLER COASTER

It's time for India's men's and women's hockey teams to **put the blinkers** on as Paris 2024 approaches.

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If roller-coaster were an adjective, Indian hockey would be the perfect example. If it were a verb, Indian hockey embodied it in all its glory. And if it were an object, Indian hockey would be the ultimate definition of it. Men, women, seniors, juniors, players, administrators — there are no outliers to unpredictability in Indian hockey, and 2023 was simply more of the same.

A year that started with the men's team being touted as one of the favourites for the World Cup in January, only to fail to reach even the quarterfinals at home, at the fortress called Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar, ended with a lone, narrow win against France in a five-nation tournament in Spain. But interspersed between the two were massive victories at the Asian Champions Trophy (ACT) at home, the biggest prize of the year, the Asian Games gold, and a ticket to the 2024 Paris Olympics.

It is the kind of unpredictability that Indian hockey teams have come to symbolise, results that make even

their fiercest supporters wary of any predictions while hoping for the best at all times. A team that easily overwhelms Germany and Australia in the FIH Pro League, less than two months after the World Cup disaster, at the same venue with almost the same players. A team where captain Harmanpreet Singh can struggle to put stick to the ball throughout the World Cup and still end up as the top scorer in the Pro League. It is a team that's poetry in motion, flourishing when everything falls into place but can as easily slip into a cacophony of discordant notes.

The World Cup loss resulted in more than just a longer wait for a shot at the big prize; it claimed coach Graham Reid and his support staff, brought in Craig Fulton, and an overhaul of the style and system of coaching. It also resulted in Paddy Upton joining the team as its first-ever full-time, travelling mind trainer. While the jury is still out on his impact, it was a long-pending demand that finally got fulfilled.

The ACT in August was the smaller of the two titles the men won in 2023 but was arguably the tougher one. For starters, the conditions were far from ideal — an unusually hot and

humid Chennai with less than 48 hours to recover from cool European climes and jetlag for their first game and stronger opponents. In contrast, the Asian Games were more about the pressure of what was at stake in a foreign land where the Indian teams were not exactly favourites. The fact that the players managed to overcome both sets of challenges speaks well of not just their ability to adjust but also their faith in Fulton's process. For the women, it was a less-than-fruitful year, but one that saw them end at sixth in the world, their best-ever return since the rankings were introduced. To finish above teams like England and New Zealand takes some doing, and even though the Asian Games bronze was not what the team would have hoped for, winning the Asian Champions Trophy just a month later, including a win against Asian Games Champion China, was the kind of boost it needed ahead of the all-important Olympic Qualifiers in January.

In Hangzhou too, the Indian women lost just one game, but that semifinal loss ended Paris hopes and put them on the longer route to the Olympics. It might leave the team with less time to prepare for the